SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #39 · LIFE-STAGE PRESSURES

“I'm a burden now that I can't work.”

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Where it often comes from

Illness, injury, disability, or age can limit work, and with it independence and income. Receiving care, relying on family, or needing help with money can feel like a burden to others. If we were always the strong one, being on the receiving side can be painful. The thought “They would be better off without me” can grow in the dark.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says that the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable. We who are strong ought to bear with the weak, and we are to bear one another’s burdens. The psalmist prays, “Do not discard me in my old age; do not forsake me when my strength fails,” and God answers, “I have made you, and I will carry you.” Receiving care is part of how the body of Christ works. A person who cannot work still holds a place in the family and in God’s heart.

> *“On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable”* (1 Corinthians 12:22).

Also see

> “Do not discard me in my old age; do not forsake me when my strength fails” (Psalm 71:9).

> “Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray. I have made you, and I will carry you; I will sustain you and deliver you” (Isaiah 46:4).

> “We who are strong ought to bear with the shortcomings of the weak and not to please ourselves” (Romans 15:1).

> “Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ” (Galatians 6:2).

Common self-statements

- My family would be better off without me.
- I am just a drain on everyone.
- I used to contribute and now I cannot.
- I am a weight on those I love.
- I should not need so much.
- I am useless now.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming that my family sees me as a burden.
- Labeling: Calling myself “a burden.”
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I am either productive or a burden.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling like a burden and concluding that I am.

Challenging questions

- What have my family members actually said or done?
- What do I give to my family that is not work, such as love, prayer, wisdom, or presence?
- If my spouse or parent were in my place, would I see them as a burden?

- What does Scripture say about those who seem weaker?
- What would it mean to receive care graciously?
- Who could I talk to about how I feel?

Truth summary

> Needing help does not make me a burden. In the body of Christ the weaker parts are indispensable, and in my family I am loved for who I am. I can receive care with grace and keep giving what I can, such as love, prayer, and presence.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Weakness
- Sickness
- Help
- Elderly
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Weak/Tired
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God's faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

Because He Lives — Bill and Gloria Gaither
This older favorite grounds courage for tomorrow in Christ's resurrection.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm a burden now that I can't work"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm a burden now that I can't work." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What have my loved ones actually said?
- ☐ What do I give that is not work?
- ☐ How would I view someone else in my place?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about the weaker parts?
- ☐ How can I receive help gracefully?
- ☐ Who can I talk with?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The weaker parts are indispensable.
- ☐ I am loved for who I am, not what I do.
- ☐ Receiving care is part of life together.
- ☐ I still have gifts to give.
- ☐ God carries me.
- ☐ I can accept help with grace.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 12:22
  "On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable."
- ☐ Psalm 71:9
  "Do not discard me in my old age; do not forsake me when my strength fails."
- ☐ Isaiah 46:4
  "Even to your old age, I will be the same, and I will bear you up when you turn gray. I have made you, and I will carry you; I will sustain you and deliver you."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ What I give: Each day, write one non-work thing you gave to someone, such as a prayer, a listening ear, or a word of thanks.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Corinthians 12:22 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The parts that seem weaker are indispensable, so I am not a burden.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Weakness" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Ask a loved one. Ask, "What does my being here mean to you?" and listen.
- ☐ List what you still give. Write ten ways you contribute that do not require work.
- ☐ Say thank you well. Practice receiving help with gratitude instead of apology.
- ☐ Talk to someone. If heavy thoughts continue, speak to a pastor, counselor, or doctor, and if you ever feel unsafe, contact a crisis line right away.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “I'm a burden now that I can't work”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A gift I gave
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm a burden now that I can't work.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, You carry me. Quiet the thought that I am a burden. Help me receive care gracefully, give what I can, and remember that I am loved by You and by those around me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.